

Finding the sanity in the insane: the Field of Computer Scientists

J. Wong

C. Wen

Department of Computational Insanity, EECS Insane Asylum

April 5, 2025

Abstract

We explore our casual observation, in which we discovered a general trend in EECS: every person is insane. However, we have also noticed that there are *degrees* to this madness: There are people in EECS, and then there is us, the authors. We seek to measure the “normal amount” of insanity in EECS, splitting the truly insane from those who are only (kind of?) insane. Therefore, from the result of this work, insanity is better defined, allowing us to find and seek people (like us) that truly make others question their existence.

1 Introduction

The authors have noticed that participation in activities associated with Computer Science, such as programming for long periods of time, reading research papers, and writing new papers, has changed the people involved. In this paper, we aim to outline these changes and examine whether there is a relationship between these and Computer Science. In a nutshell, to quote a meme, “Are you insane because you’re in Computer Science, or are you in Computer Science because you are insane?”. We also add in the third option that there is no correlation between the two variables and the authors are simply victims of apophenia, which is, suitably, another indication of insanity.

2 Literature Review

There is no literature to review. We are too insane for prior art to cover our insanity. Perhaps read some Dostoevsky, Kafka, or Camus to set the mood!

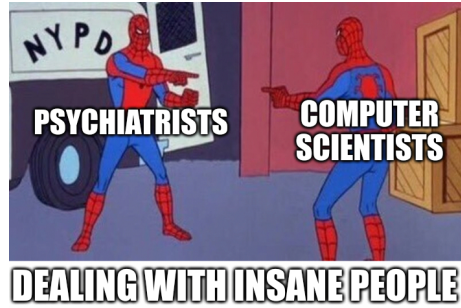


Fig 1. We also have to deal with ~~insane~~ people ourselves

3 Method

We surveyed a group of primarily students from a not-so random selection in multiple colleges and universities. Furthermore, we also surveyed a few industry workers. They answered a list of primarily multiple-choice questions. These questions are derived from our experience.

3.1 Subjective Answers

We asked two questions that are part of this section. First is how good the participant feels at Computer Science, with a range from 1-5. We anchored 1 at “Just Started Yesterday”, while 5 is anchored at “Can work on $P=NP$ level problems”. Next, we asked them about the main correlation of this study, which is how insane the participant feels that they are. We had the same 1-5 range as with the previous question, with 1 anchored with “I am fine and mentally healthy”, and 5 anchored at “I desperately need therapy and help today”.

The most important subjective factor that participants responded to was their emotional attachment to their primary computing device, ranging from 1 to 10, with 1 anchored at “I can destroy it with no emotional reaction”, and 10 anchored at “love of my life”. Emotional attachment to objects can be a sign of coping with having no friends or unreliable ones [10]. Furthermore, attachment to a computing device can predict one’s attachment style [11], which has established correlations to the additional questions we asked. Finally, the authors also posit that as a corollary of attachment to a primary computing device, computer scientists are too attached to their work to form proper human attachments.

3.2 Objective Answers

This section is more about the objective factors of insanity. We also asked about years of experience and degrees/academic rank as the correlating factor.

We asked about objective experience using a similar scale to the United

States Census [4] [19]. However, we remove the parts below collegiate-level education, as Computer Science Education often only formally starts in college (unfortunately) [9]. We also added tiers beyond the Doctoral Degree, with Post-doctorate, Professor, and Distinguished Professor/Scientist in computer science. Finally, we ask about years of experience in computer science, to round out the experience of participants that cannot be captured in academic achievements.

Another factor surveyed is the field(s) in which the EECS participants are in. We would also like to find the field(s) that have the most insanity in them.

We also invented our own “measurement of insanity” based on the “psych dungeon” floor bosses, listed below. Participants were asked to answer where they were on this scale in terms of objective treatment for mental health.

Final Bosses of the Psych Dungeon, per floor

1. Undergraduate Practicum Student
2. Graduate Practicum Student
3. New Grad, Associate Therapist
4. Licensed Therapist
5. Psychologist
6. Psychiatrist
7. Mental Hospital Doctor
8. Psych Ward Doctor
9. Postdoc Fellow
10. Professor
11. Subject-matter expert

Insanity Scale, based on the loot drops from each floor’s Final Boss

1. I have no personal issues in my life that cause me distress
2. I have no personal issues in my life that require me to see a therapist
3. I believe that I have at least one undiagnosed mental disorder
4. I have been diagnosed with at least one mental disorder
5. I am on medication for my mental disorder(s)
6. I have been in a psychiatric hospital for my mental issues
7. I have been in a psychiatric asylum for my mental issues
8. I have been professionally studied individually or in a small group, and papers were published about me

Next, to continue the data points about insanity, we asked about weekly showering numbers, along with other points of data that indicate a lack of self-care in exchange for additional time with computer science, as Gibbons concludes that “self-neglect is [related] to complex health and social circumstances and to an individual’s ability and willingness” [7]. Anyways, showers per week included fractional numbers, as many computer scientists don’t shower [16] [22]. However, it is important to note that some computer scientists, including the authors, shower to replace the lack of emotional warmth in their lives. This is also why we surveyed for the length of a participant’s average shower and the perception of how warm their shower is, as those factors are correlated with how lonely they are [2].



Fig 2. u/greensecond, “he cant do that” [20]

Another question asked was “How often do you forget to take care of yourself (e.g. eating, cleaning yourself, sleeping) when doing computer science?”, to measure self-neglect as a result of computer science. We also asked an additional question about forgetting to sleep due to computer science explicitly due to prior work stating [23] [21] [12] [15] that programmers don’t sleep due to problems in their code.

Another factor to measure misery was crying to sleep and crying in the shower. We ask about crying episodes per week. As mentioned previously, we believe the attachment to a primary computing device is correlated to this statistic, as computer scientists are too busy to develop a consistent, healthy statement style to non-computing devices and entities such as humans. Therefore, the crying episodes should be more frequent with a preoccupied style [3], something associated with attachment to objects [26].

Objectively, the best way to measure insanity is trips to psychiatric hospitals (grippy sock jail). We also ask about evasion from grippy sock jail police to account for self-neglect in receiving mental health treatment. Vogel et al. states that there are five reasons for avoiding mental help [24]. They are social stigma, treatment fears, fear of emotion, anticipated utility and risks, and self-disclosure. We did not ask participants about if and why they avoid mental help, as this is a study about how insane Computer Scientists and related are, not why we

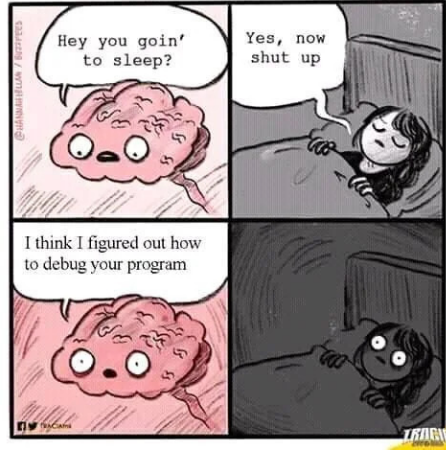


Fig 3. u/Xevitz, “Why developers don’t sleep” [23]

are insane. Rest assured that our form was anonymous and responses were randomized; emails were only collected to give out gift cards.

We also asked about the participants’ friendships. Having friends, especially close friends, is beneficial for mental health. In fact, people with friends are generally more satisfied with their lives and less likely to be depressed [5]. It also makes one more likely to not die early [17].

Another factor surveyed was whether the participant was in love with someone. Being in love with someone increases life satisfaction [1], while the inverse causes one to be less satisfied with life [18]. Furthermore, it should be noted that attachment anxiety is associated with a stronger desire for a partner [13], something measured with a question on how long the participant wants to change their relationship status. We posit that the people in the computer science population are not in love with someone, and even if they are, the love they have for someone is unrequited. Therefore, we asked if participants’ love for someone is unrequited.

3.3 “Optional” Answers

We also stood to find additional evidence to one of last year’s SIGBOVIK submissions, “Programming Socks: Is it high time for thigh-highs? An investigation into the perceived unreasonable effectiveness of Programming Socks on productivity levels in the field of Software Engineering” [8]. This has nothing to do with our current study, other than potentially discovering the strength of the computer scientists who participated. We asked three questions: whether the participant wears programming socks, whether the participant wears programming skirts, and if the programming equipment listed would help them program.

Update: not a lot (20%) of participants wore/believed that programming socks/skirts are effective for programming.

4 Results

For analysis, we chose to separate our participants (N=15) into three categories: CS (Computer Scientist) (N=3), CS (Computer Science) major (N=9), and CS-adjacent (like Computer Engineering, Informatics, and Computational Science) (N=3). We noticed basically no correlation between subjective strength in computer science, and subjective insanity ($r=.072$). However, the mean subjective insanity, something we stood to find out, was actually not that high (3.2/10).

Subjective Insanity	Mean	Median
CS	3.00	2.0
CS Major	3.66	4.0
CS-adjacent	2.00	2.0
All	3.20	3.0

Table 1: Subjective Insanity Scores (out of ten)

Subjective CS Strength	Mean	Median
CS	2.66	3.0
CS Major	3.66	4.0
CS-adjacent	3.00	3.0
All	3.33	3.0

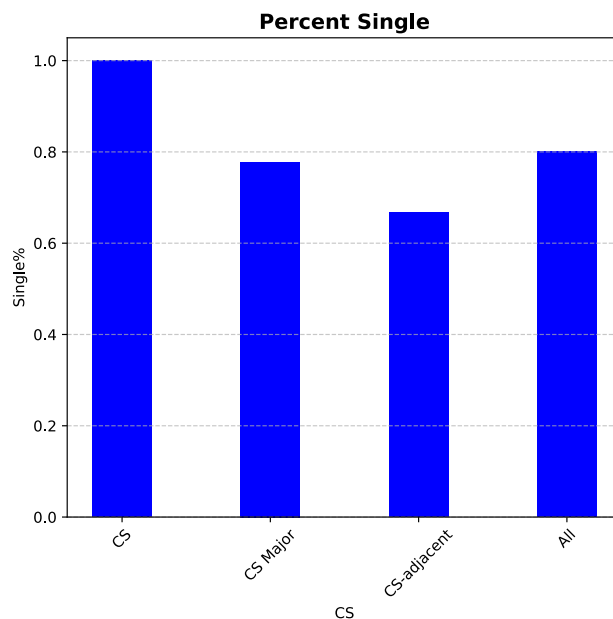
Table 2: Subjective CS Strength (out of ten)

Objective measures of insanity are also lower than we previously thought. However, 40% of participants having mental health issues—and up to two-thirds when including undiagnosed disorders—is a significant concern if these findings are able to be generalized to the broader Computer Science community

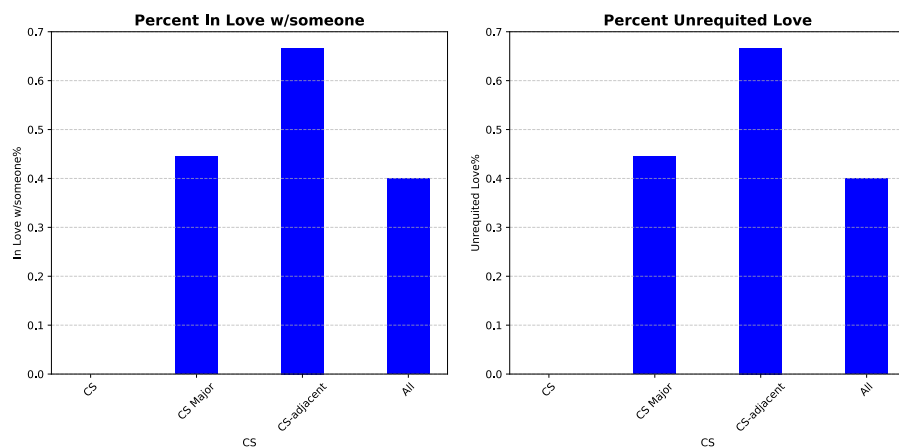
	No Distress	No Therapy	1≤ Undiagnosed Mental Disorder	1≤ Diagnosed Mental Disorder	Di-Visit to Psychiatric Hospital
All	6.67	26.67	26.67	33.33	6.67

Table 3: Objective Insanity Measures (Categorical - %)

5 Discussion



The authors' reactions to this graph are “data shows 🤖” and “💀 rip”, respectively.



From our observations, the Computer Scientists gave up, at least for the meantime. For example, Miller, a computational linguist, notes his status will likely take 67 years to change, longer than the rest of his life expectancy [14] 🤖🤖🤖. Interestingly, Computer Scientists (CS) seem to have the most hope, with the shortest average time to change their relationship status at $3.\overline{33}$ years. On the other hand, CS majors have less hope, with their average at $3.\overline{77}$ years.

Years to Change Relationship Status	Mean	Median
CS	3. $\overline{33}$	4.0
CS Major	3. $\overline{77}$	3.0
CS-adjacent	3. $\overline{66}$	1.0
All	3. $\overline{66}$	3.0

Table 4: Self-Reported Estimated Years to Change Relationship Status

Surprisingly, some CS, INCLUDING THE AUTHORS, do actually shower, a lot more than traditionally expected, with the minimum in our dataset being 2 showers a week. The authors posit the cause of the showering is to replace the lack of emotional warmth (shower warmth was about a (4/5) for all of CS) in their lives 🥹, as mentioned previously and in prior studies [2].

Showers Per Week	Mean	Median
CS	5. $\overline{66}$	7.0
CS Major	5.50	5.0
CS-adjacent	5. $\overline{33}$	6.0
All	5.50	6.0

Table 5: Showers per Week by Group

It is surprising to note that the CS Majors have the most attachment to their primary computing devices. Their median of years of experience in computer science is the highest. However, note that there is actually a slightly weak negative correlation with attachment to primary computing device and years of experience CS (-.256).

We did find out that CS, on average, actually had the least amount of experience in CS (in terms of years). It seems like we have attracted participants who haven't declared a CS major, rather than people who have exited their education. This could be due to the sample group we surveyed as well. Furthermore, the CS-adjacent average is very high due to the large mode, along with a low amount of participants $N = 9$.

Years of XP in CS	Mean	Median	Mode
CS	1.00	1.0	1
CS Major	5. $\overline{22}$	5.0	6
CS-adjacent	7. $\overline{33}$	4.0	17
All	4.80	4.0	17

Table 6: Years of Experience in CS by Group

6 Limitations

The authors have like, zero friends, so like we couldn't really get a vast enough dataset to generalize to all of Computer Science [6]. It should be noted that the authors went into public Discord guilds and bribed around ~~supposed to be~~ 20 15 people \$5 each to participate in this study, considering that asking our friends would be (1) using a non-random sample space and (2) impractical as we do not have so many friends. Unfortunately, due to using incentives, we are also too broke to gather a larger sample size. Furthermore, by the principle of attraction/similarity-attraction relationships [25], our sample group is most likely more insane than a normal group. Therefore, for further research, the researchers should be "normally" insane, and there should be a more normal group that is more representative of the total population in Computer Science.

References

- [1] Menelaos Apostolou et al. "Emotional wellbeing and life satisfaction of singles and mated people across 12 nations". In: *Evolutionary Psychological Science* 10.4 (2024), pp. 352–369.
- [2] John A. Bargh and Idit Shalev. "The Substitutability of Physical and Social Warmth in Daily Life". In: *Emotion* 12.1 (2012), pp. 154–162. DOI: 10.1037/a0023527.
- [3] Kim Bartholomew and Leonard M Horowitz. "Attachment styles among young adults: a test of a four-category model." In: *Journal of personality and social psychology* 61.2 (1991), p. 226.
- [4] Dan Black, Seth Sanders, and Lowell Taylor. "Measurement of higher education in the census and current population survey". In: *Journal of the American Statistical Association* 98.463 (2003), pp. 545–554.
- [5] Karmel W Choi et al. "An exposure-wide and Mendelian randomization approach to identifying modifiable factors for the prevention of depression". In: *American Journal of Psychiatry* 177.10 (2020), pp. 944–954.
- [6] Patrick W Corrigan et al. "Familiarity with and social distance from people who have serious mental illness". In: *Psychiatric services* 52.7 (2001), pp. 953–958.
- [7] Susanne W. Gibbons. "Theory Synthesis for Self-Neglect: A Health and Social Phenomenon". In: *Nursing Research* 58.3 (May 2009), pp. 194–200. DOI: 10.1097/NNR.0b013e3181a3092c.
- [8] Ian F.V.G. Hunter. "Programming Socks: Is it high time for thigh-highs? An investigation into the perceived unreasonable effectiveness of Programming Socks on productivity levels in the field of Software Engineering". In: *Proceedings of SIGBOVIK 2024*. 2024. URL: <https://www.sigbovik.org/2024/proceedings.pdf#page=10>.

- [9] Carolyn Jones. *A shortage of teachers for computer science classes puts California near the bottom of a national instruction ranking*. Accessed: 2025-03-27. 2023. URL: <https://calmatters.org/education/k-12-education/2023/10/computer-science-classes/>.
- [10] Lucas A Keefer et al. "Attachment to objects as compensation for close others' perceived unreliability". In: *Journal of Experimental Social Psychology* 48.4 (2012), pp. 912–917.
- [11] Veronika Konok et al. "Humans' attachment to their mobile phones and its relationship with interpersonal attachment style". In: *Computers in Human Behavior* 61 (2016), pp. 537–547.
- [12] Matt Layman. "How Sleep Affects Your Code". In: (2019). Accessed: 2025-03-28. URL: <https://www.mattlayman.com/blog/2019/how-sleep-affects-your-code/>.
- [13] Geoff MacDonald and Yoobin Park. "Associations of attachment avoidance and anxiety with life satisfaction, satisfaction with singlehood, and desire for a romantic partner". In: *Personal relationships* 29.1 (2022), pp. 163–176.
- [14] Tristan Miller. "Why I Will Never Have a Girlfriend". In: *The Annals of Improbable Research* 8.3 (Dec. 1999). German Research Center for Artificial Intelligence, pp. 13–17.
- [15] Mariko Nishikitani et al. "Influence of overtime work, sleep duration, and perceived job characteristics on the physical and mental status of software engineers". In: *Industrial health* 43.4 (2005), pp. 623–629.
- [16] Phoenix Pham. "Computer Science Department to Offer Extra Credit for Showering". In: *The Badger Herald* (Oct. 2022). URL: <https://badgerherald.com/banter/2022/10/07/computer-science-department-to-offer-extra-credit-for-showering/>.
- [17] Timothy Smith, Julianne Holt-Lunstad, and J Bradley Layton. "Social relationships and mortality risk: a meta-analytic review". In: (2010).
- [18] Julia Stern et al. "Differences between lifelong singles and ever-partnered individuals in Big Five personality traits and life satisfaction". In: *Psychological Science* 35.12 (2024), pp. 1364–1381.
- [19] U.S. Census Bureau. *Why We Ask About Education*. Accessed: 2025-03-27. 2025. URL: <https://www.census.gov/acs/www/about/why-we-ask-each-question/education/>.
- [20] u/greensecond. *He can't do that!* Accessed: 2025-03-27. 2022. URL: https://www.reddit.com/r/ProgrammerHumor/comments/w8fsop/he_cant_do_that/.
- [21] u/Jdbye. *Is it normal to stay up 2 days coding without sleeping?* Accessed: 2025-03-28. 2023. URL: https://www.reddit.com/r/AskProgramming/comments/14xicny/is_it_normal_to_stay_up_2_days_coding_without/.

- [22] u/Upper-Feedback-9968. *PSA: Fellow CS majors, please, please, please take a shower.* accessed 2025-03-29. 2021. URL: https://www.reddit.com/r/VirginiaTech/comments/rbz4lp/psa_fellow_cs_majors_please_please_please_take_a/.
- [23] u/Xevitz. *Why Developers Don't Sleep.* Accessed: 2025-03-28. 2018. URL: https://www.reddit.com/r/ProgrammerHumor/comments/872kzi/why_developers_dont_sleep/.
- [24] David L Vogel, Stephen R Wester, and Lisa M Larson. “Avoidance of counseling: Psychological factors that inhibit seeking help”. In: *Journal of counseling & development* 85.4 (2007), pp. 410–422.
- [25] Christopher G Wetzel and Chester A Insko. “The similarity-attraction relationship: Is there an ideal one?” In: *Journal of Experimental Social Psychology* 18.3 (1982), pp. 253–276.
- [26] Gregor Žvelc. “Object relations and attachment styles in adulthood”. In: *Psihološka obzorja* 19.2 (2010), pp. 5–18.